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GitHub Copilot CLI Core Components

Prompts, instructions, hooks, skills and MCP servers: what each one does and where it lives.



OVERVIEW

The Five Components

1	**Prompts**	What you ask Copilot to do.
2	**Instructions**	Rules it follows in every session.
3	**Hooks**	Your scripts that run on session events.
4	**Skills**	Playbooks it loads when a task needs one.
5	**MCP servers**	Connections to outside tools and data.

HOW IT WORKS

How the Components Fit Together

1

Instructions

Load when the session starts and apply to every answer.

2

Your prompt

You describe the task you want done.

3

Skills

Load only if the task matches a skill's description.

4

MCP servers

Provide the tools Copilot calls to do the work.

5

Hooks

Run on events such as sessionStart or preToolUse.

Hooks fire at several points in a session.

A preToolUse hook runs before a tool call and can deny it. A postToolUse hook runs after it.

COMPONENT 1 OF 5

Prompts

The request you type. Everything else shapes how Copilot answers it.

- Say the goal, the files involved and how to check the result.
- Point at files with @ instead of pasting them.
- Use plan mode first for bigger changes.

Reusable prompts belong in a skill. Prompt files (.prompt.md) are not described in the Copilot CLI docs.

WAYS TO PROMPT

`copilot`	Start an interactive session
`copilot -p "…"`	Send one prompt without a session
`@src/app.js`	Attach a file as context
`!git status`	Run a shell command, no model call
`/mcp, /skills`	Slash commands inside a session
`Shift+Tab`	Toggle plan mode
`Esc Esc`	Stop a running task

COMPONENT 2 OF 5

Instructions

Always-on guidance, loaded at the start of every session.

- Coding standards, build and test commands, team conventions.
- Repo-wide, path-specific (with an applyTo glob) or personal.
- All instruction files combine; none replaces another.

Skip them for one session with --no-custom-instructions. Guidance for a single workflow belongs in a skill.

WHERE IT LIVES

```
AGENTS.md
.github/copilot-instructions.md
.github/instructions/**/*.instructions.md
~/.copilot/copilot-instructions.md
```

EXAMPLE

```
---
applyTo: "**/*.ts"
---
Use strict types. Run npm test
before finishing a change.
```

COMPONENT 3 OF 5

Hooks

Your own shell commands, run at set points in a session.

- Guard tools: a preToolUse hook can deny a call before it runs.
- Log and audit prompts, tool calls and errors.
- A crashing preToolUse hook denies the call; a timeout lets it through.

Events: sessionStart, sessionEnd, userPromptSubmitted, preToolUse, postToolUse, errorOccurred, agentStop, subagentStop

WHERE IT LIVES

```
.github/hooks/*.json
~/.copilot/hooks/*.json
```

EXAMPLE

```
{
  "version": 1,
  "hooks": {
    "preToolUse": [{
      "bash": "./scripts/check.sh",
      "timeoutSec": 10
    }]
  }
}
```

COMPONENT 4 OF 5

Skills

A playbook for one kind of task, loaded only when it is needed.

- Copilot picks a skill from its description, or you call it with /skill-name.
- A folder with a SKILL.md, plus any scripts and reference files.
- Manage them with /skills list, /skills info and /skills reload.

Use a skill for repeatable workflows and fixed output formats. Use instructions for rules that apply to everything.

WHERE IT LIVES

```
.github/skills/<name>/SKILL.md
~/.copilot/skills/<name>/SKILL.md
```

EXAMPLE

```
---
name: failure-debugging
description: Debug failing CI
  workflows.
---
Read the failing job's log first.
Then list the likely causes.
```

COMPONENT 5 OF 5

MCP Servers

A connection to an outside tool or data source, run as a server.

- The GitHub MCP server is built in. Add others for your own systems.
- Local servers start a command; remote servers use a URL.
- Manage them with /mcp, /mcp show NAME, /mcp enable and /mcp disable.

Add a server only when the built-in tools do not cover the job.

WHERE IT LIVES

`~/.copilot/mcp-config.json`

EXAMPLE

```
{
  "mcpServers": {
    "playwright": {
      "type": "local",
      "command": "npx",
      "args": ["@playwright/mcp@latest"],
      "tools": ["*"]
    }
  }
}
```

COMPARISON

When to Use Which

Component	Use it for	When it applies	Where it lives
Prompts	One-off requests and questions	Each time you send one	Typed in the session
Instructions	Standards and conventions that always apply	Session start	Repo files, or ~/.copilot/
Hooks	Guardrails, logging and checks on events	On the event they name	.github/hooks/
Skills	Repeatable workflows needed some of the time	When relevant, or /name	.github/skills/
MCP servers	Tools and data from outside systems	Once added, when a task needs them	~/.copilot/mcp-config.json

FILE LOCATIONS

Where the Files Live

IN THE REPOSITORY

```
your-repo/
  AGENTS.md
  .github/
    copilot-instructions.md
    instructions/*.instructions.md
    hooks/*.json
    skills/<name>/SKILL.md
```

IN YOUR HOME FOLDER

```
~/.copilot/
  copilot-instructions.md
  hooks/*.json
  skills/<name>/SKILL.md
  mcp-config.json
```

Repository files travel with the code and apply to everyone who clones it. Home-folder files apply to you on every project. MCP servers are set up per user, in mcp-config.json or with /mcp add.

RECAP

Key Takeaways

- **Prompts** say what you want right now.
- **Instructions** say how Copilot should always behave.
- **Hooks** enforce rules with your own scripts.
- **Skills** package a workflow that loads only when needed.
- **MCP servers** give Copilot tools beyond the built-in ones.

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Thank you.

With people and technology, we make our world better.

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